

Portlet Development With Liferay

Here's a tutorial on developing JSR-286 portlets for the Liferay platform.

Portlets are small applications that are rendered in the larger context of a portal. When you view any of the popular portals like Yahoo! or Rediff, you see the home page organised into small boxes displaying mail, news, photos, advertisements and other details. These boxes are called portlets. To develop portlets, there are various competing (and sometimes cooperating) technologies: Google Gadgets; Microsoft Sharepoint Portal; and in the world of Java, we have two specifications -- JSR-286 and JSR-168 -- that govern Portlet development. JSR-286 supersedes JSR-168, and is mostly compatible with its predecessor. JSR-286 is sometimes called the Portlet 2.0 specification. The portlet specification is similar to the Java Servlet specification. Understanding the servlet API would shorten the process of learning Portlet technology.

Portlet containers

Portlet containers house the deployed portlets and render them in the context of the portal. There are various portlet containers in the market. WebLogic Portal and WebSphere Portal are popular proprietary portal servers. In the open source space, we have Liferay [www.liferay.com], JBoss Portal [www.jboss.org/jbossportal], OpenPortal [portal.dev.java.net], Pluto [portals.apache.org/pluto] and others.

Liferay

After a small evaluation of different Portal servers, I shortlisted Liferay. Here is a list of the winning points:

- Support for the latest standards and specifications
- Various innovations in the UI layer
- An extensive set of pre-build ready-to-deploy portlets
- A good community
- Open development

Liferay installation

The only prerequisite to install Liferay is that you should have the Java Development Kit in your system. Liferay downloads are conveniently packaged with various application servers and servlet containers. Download the one that you are comfortable with, and extract it. The installation is then complete. The extracted directory will be called *LIFERAY_DIR* hereafter.

Prerequisites

Software prerequisites

1. JDK 1.6
2. Maven 2.1
3. Liferay 5.2

Knowledge prerequisites

A working knowledge of the following technologies will be helpful:

1. Servlets
2. JSP
3. JSTL and EL